

Session 22: Design Patterns and Literary Units

Key Takeaways

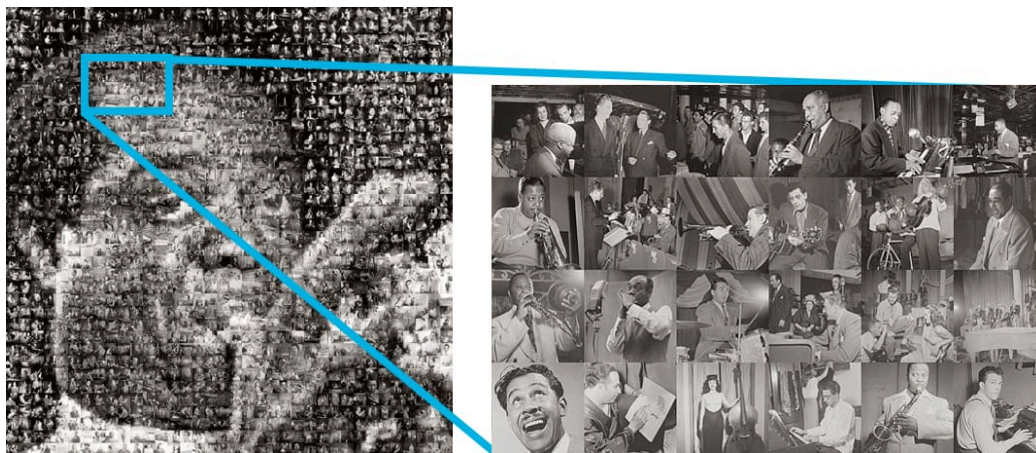
- The Bible is like a photomosaic with identifiable smaller literary units crafted and arranged to work together and create a larger, overarching message.
- Biblical authors use repeated scenes, often with slight variations, to develop themes throughout the story.
- A concordance is a very helpful tool for identifying repeated words and phrases in our Bibles.

Design Patterns and Literary Analysis

Recall our earlier exploration of the origins of the Hebrew Bible and how it's a collection of collections that has been written, adapted, and edited into a unified whole. Let's take a look at two additional analogies that will help us understand the significance of this fact for how we read and interpret biblical literature.

Analogy 1: The Photomosaic

This portrait of Louis Armstrong, created by Robert Silvers, consists of hundreds of smaller photos taken from actual recording sessions with Louis Armstrong.



Silvers, Robert (2000). *Louis Armstrong*. Photomosaic.com.

The unique unity of the larger photomosaic is achieved precisely by its composite nature. The thematic arrangement of light/dark/gray tiny squares becomes a tool in the artists hand to create larger patterns of color that provide an ordered, unified picture of the subject.

The Hebrew Bible displays this kind of mosaic unity on a large- and small-scale level.

Analogy 2: Repeated Motifs and Themes in Film

Movie directors often create a cohesive unity with the themes and plotline of a story by repetition and variation. By building up viewer expectations through repetition, the director can introduce variation and surprise.

In *The Lord of the Rings* film trilogy, consider the motif of the “ring temptation” scene. Some characters are tempted by the ring’s power and they succumb to it (Smeagol, Boromir, Frodo). Other characters resist its power, but in different ways: Bilbo (just barely), Gandalf and Galadriel (through fear and trembling), and Aragorn (like it’s no problem!).

This diverse set of responses to the ring’s power creates a rich palette of characters and a complex portrait of power in the story.



Jackson, P. (Director). (2001-2003). *The Lord of the Rings Series* [Film]. New Line Cinema.

The biblical authors were masters of this technique. In fact, this basic principle of patterned repetition and analogy is the most fundamental tool in their repertoire. And it’s accomplished through the simplest of means: strategic repetition of key words.

Identifying Literary Units (Segmentation)

These two analogies illustrate different features of the TaNaK collection, which creates the need for two related reading strategies.

1. Identifying literary units (segmentation): Just as a photomosaic consists of hundreds of smaller photos, so the epic biblical narrative consists of hundreds of smaller episodes. Learning to identify the beginning and ending of literary units that make up the larger mosaic of a biblical book helps the reader begin to see the structure of the text.
2. Identifying repeated words and themes that weave the literary units together (coordination): Just as the smaller photos in a photomosaic are organized according to patterns of color, light, and tone, so the literary units of the biblical narrative are woven together through patterns of repeated words, themes, and images. These repetitions invite the reader to see continuity and an ongoing argument that develops through the course of the story.

The next session will explore coordination, the strategy of identifying repeated words and themes.

Markers of Literary Units in Narrative

If we imagine the individual images in a photomosaic or the smallest pieces of a quilt, then segmentation means paying attention to the boundaries of the smallest literary unit. The biblical authors have a wide variety of techniques to indicate the opening and conclusion of literary units, depending on literary genre and context. The most helpful introduction to this method of study is found in David Dorsey's book, *The Literary Structure of the Old Testament*, chapters 1-5.

To identify the boundary markers of these literary units, one key strategy is to watch for a shift in character, time, setting, or plot.

Example: The addition of new characters and shifting to a new time and setting, like when Abram and Sarai go to Egypt and Pharaoh is introduced in Genesis 12:10-20. The action initiated in the unit's beginning comes to a resolution at its end, like in [Joshua 2:1](#) (the spies are sent) and [Joshua 2:23-24](#) (the spies return).

Another feature of biblical narrative that can help us identify unit markers is when the authors clearly mark the conclusion of one narrative by the beginning of the following unit, as in Genesis chapters 14, 15, and 16 (see [14:1](#) , [15:1](#) , [16:1](#) , etc.).

Hierarchies of Literary Units in Biblical Narrative

When all of the above principles are applied to a literary analysis of Genesis 2-3, it yields the following outline of the Eden narrative.

Verses	Unit	Part	Movement
2:4-6 No garden, humans, or rain	2:4-17 From Wasteland to Eden	2:4-25 From Isolated Wasteland to Communion in Eden	2:4-3:24 The Eden Narrative: From Garden to Exile
2:7-9 God plants a garden and forms human			
2:10-14 The Eden river flows to become four rivers			
2:15-17 Human put in the garden + divine command			
2:18-20 Problem: a human alone	2:18-25 From Isolation to Communion		
2:21-23 Solution: two humans out of			
<i>Identifying the Literary Units of Genesis 2-3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).</i>			

Verses	Unit	Part	Movement
one			
2:24-25 Two humans married			
3:1-5 Dialogue between snake and woman	3:1-13 Folly and the Fall		
3:6-7 Woman and man eat from the tree			
3:8-13 Dialogue between God and humans			
3:14-15 Curse on the snake	3:14-24 The Fallout	3:14-24 The Fallout and Exile from Eden	
3:16 Consequences for the woman			
3:17-19 Consequences for the man			
3:20-21 Provision of garments			
3:22-24 Humans exiled from Eden			
Identifying the Literary Units of Genesis 2-3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).			

When the same information is displayed in a vertical form, you can begin to see the hierarchy of context for any given story, which is itself made up of many nested layers of smaller episodes and scenes.

Genesis 1-50													
Genesis 1-11													
Genesis 2:4-3:24 - The Eden Narrative													
2:4-25							3:1-13			3:14-24			
2:4-17				2:18-25			3:1-5	3:6-7	3:8-13	3:14-21			3:22-24
2:4-6	2:7-9	2:10-14	2:15-17	2:18-20	2:21-23	2:45-25				3:14-15	3:16	3:17-19	3:20-21

Nesting Literary Units in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

This segmentation of biblical narrative is immensely helpful as a first step in understanding, but it raises the need for the next step: studying how all these different literary units have been woven together with developing themes and ideas. This is the study of coordination in biblical narrative.

Reflection Question

What are some different ways to identify where literary units begin and end? Why is this important?